The Commentary on Begging

Bhikṣuvṛtti · Toh 1234 · Derge Tengyur
སྙན་མའི་འགྲེལ་པ།

The Commentary on Begging, known in Sanskrit as the Bhikṣuvṛtti and in Tibetan as Slongmo'i Drelpa, is a short tantric work attributed in its colophon to the Indian adept Ḍombipa. Opening with homage to Mañjuśrī, it presents begging for alms as a yogic discipline. It treats the yogin's daily round of begging as a practice joined with mantra recitation, control of the winds, worship of the yoginīs and Vajrayoginī, and a view of all things as empty and illusory. Written mostly in verse with passages of prose, it also gives instructions on syllables, mantras and diagrams, and a song sung while begging. It is Toh 1234 in the Tengyur, in the section of commentaries on the tantras. Its colophon says it was translated into Tibetan in Nepal by Jitakarṇa and the monk Nyima Gyaltsen Palzangpo.

In the language of India: bhikṣu bṛtti nāma. In the language of Tibet: The Commentary on Begging.

Homage to Mañjuśrī in youthful form.

Glorious one, meaning of yantra and mantra,
lord from whom awareness definitively arises,
who burns away the net of conceptual thought:
to glorious Mañjughoṣa I pay homage.

The lotus of the holy guru's feet
I attended for six years without doubting thought;
the supreme pollen of its anthers
I applied well, and so came the great begging.
Then, casting off great pride,
in a trackless, sky-like, desolate place,
always with the practice of loving kindness,
one should certainly and always practice begging.

First having served and honored the guru,
one composes and analyzes the sādhana of one's choice.
The yogin of hearing, reflection and meditation
places its meaning in his heart.
Then, having made offerings before him,
seated in the vajra cross-legged posture,

he fully restrains the life-wind;
the one of excellent mind should do mantra recitation.
For the guardians of the directions, at a place of corpses,
he sets out torma and recites a hundred thousand times.
The yogin who wears the directions as his garment
should dwell in the charnel grounds.
To the great yogin who acts in this way
it grants the supreme fruit of realization and liberation.

"Beg" means that, through recitation,
one practices the unchanging discipline.
With a staff and a wooden bowl,
the fortunate one with a vessel of liquor,
through the supreme of outer objects,
holds that the mind should rest.
With feet steady and firm one sits,
gazing at the tip of the nose, fixing the gaze,
thoroughly endowed with union, in signless space;
so too the mind, the quality of the life-force.
With the nine doors fully purified,
one truly practices in nine villages.
Whatever thinks in terms of existence and nonexistence,
that one should not think on nor meditate upon.
Joining the syllable hūṃ to the mind,
one should utter the four syllables.
Not out of attachment to gifts, from house to house,
not speaking of great and small:
whoever knows the unchanging,
he attains the clear mudrā.
He fully seizes the ten winds;
the ten are the light of sun and moon.
By fully uniting method and wisdom
one should go out to beg for alms.
There, with longing, one sings the song
of realizing the four abodes of Brahmā:
bhuñja i ma a ṇa sa hā ba da ka ma i so sa i ā la
mo a o dharmā ka raṇḍa ṇa mā ra u kā ma sa hā u

accha akkha ru je bu na i so saṃ sā ra mi mukka
bahma ma he sa ra ṇā rā a ṇā sakkha u su dha sa hā ba

Attaining the unchanging word,
one abides in the unchanging word.
Whoever says "bhikṣante hi,"
his gains are fully secured.

Then I shall explain the recitation.
At the end of the four syllables of the vowel series,
it is adorned with the three;
above it a crescent moon,
and above that the nāda.
What is to be known beyond that
is the fourth syllable as well.
At the end of the syllables hūṃ hūṃ, phaṭ:
the mantra of bliss should be uttered.
The rosary for the mantra is of human bone;
one hundred and eight is the offering.
One truly practices the discipline of aspiration,
fully abandoning attachment and aversion.
The yogin of whichever of the four,
of the Great God (Śiva), clear and connected,
does not beg in the ordinary way:
he is the fortunate one, of pure and certain mind.

Moreover:
The syllable bhi joins fully with realization;
the syllable kṣaṃ is the continuum of liberation;
the syllable de blocks the lower realms;
the syllable hi is the supreme unchanging.
The syllable bha is well established as "the sun";
the syllable a is held to be the figure of the moon;
the syllable ka is the piśāca who brings good fortune;
the syllable śa always tends the water for the hands;
the syllable ā, the supreme guru, is seen as the guru;
the syllable ma is Venus, the supreme lord;
the syllable ma is held to be Saturn.
These are the supreme controllers there.

Moreover:
The syllable bha is declared to be form;
the syllable ma is said to be one-pointedness;
the syllable ka is the enjoyment of scent;
the syllable ṣa is called taste;
the tangible is declared to be the syllable a;
the syllable hi is emptiness;
the syllable ma destroys pride.
The beautiful discipline of things and no-things:
I bow to glorious Vajrayoginī.
Always, outwardly and inwardly,
one engages everywhere and truly practices.

First, faultlessly, one properly worships the yoginī and abandons the various stains of the Lesser Vehicle (Hīnayāna). After that, with the mind resting in compassion like the sky, undistracted, begging into a human skull as the supreme vessel is highly praised. Just as one directly contemplates, so, like the yogic food and drink in the abode of the various goddesses, wherever one manifestly thinks of bliss and wishes to experience it directly through the union of the hero, one should do this at all times. Then one should eat the food obtained by begging and be loving toward all sentient beings.

The yogin who applies himself to consciousness alone first meditates in the state of a jackal or a dog. Then, having understood worldly thinking, he cultivates the worldly mind. Likewise, having bought clothes for the yoginīs, the liquor seller, the ḍombī, the caṇḍālī and the bosmo, one should worship each of them individually throughout six months. One should regard the whole world in accordance with the qualities of primordial wisdom. Through correct application of the winds, one should say, "Beg alms." The words "having fully abandoned the harm of attachment, aversion and delusion, one should eat camphor" carry a special meaning. The nine villages are truly practiced as the nine doors fully purified. In a vessel like a white lotus, one holds the five nectars and the various fragrances of the substances, and meditates. Abiding on the path where the families of the path gather and dwell, one says, "Beg alms," and gazes fixedly at the tip of the nose. One fully meditates on one's own mind as the inseparability of emptiness and compassion.

On the thirteenth vowel: a crescent moon, an empty circle and the nāda. On the second vowel: a syllable endowed with space and joined in conjunction. On

the sixth vowel: a crescent moon, a bindu and the nāda. In the grid of the source of phenomena, pure in body, speech and mind, the twenty-three are set out according to the rite. On a beautiful vessel of pure form, purified by the five nectars and the rest, one writes with vermilion using a golden pen: u a ja ra a u ā re a ha ī i re pha a ḍa sa bha a ḍa ā ka ā na ī i e ha ū paṃ pha u ḍa uṃ. In due order one sets out the letters that are the form of the mantra. The form of the yoginī is just as it is, of an age between youth and middle age. This is for good harvests and for accomplishing the tasks and needs of all sentient beings. By relying properly on the eight word-stations, life is well sustained.

oṃ āḥ hūṃ phaṭ svā hā. oṃ āḥ i hūṃ phaṭ svā hā. oṃ āḥ ṣa hūṃ phaṭ svā hā. oṃ āḥ ko hūṃ phaṭ svā hā. oṃ ā da hūṃ phaṭ svā hā. oṃ āḥ e hūṃ phaṭ svā hā.

On a rosary of white human bone one properly recites these mantras. The yogin, fearless like a lion, practices thoroughly in the three worlds. The proper utterance of the vowel series and the consonant series is the nature of the sun and the moon. The definitive dissolution of the winds is the nature of the five maṇḍalas. Through directly knowing its nature, it becomes the domain of one who holds to the nature. One becomes fully certain of the nature of things and of no-things. Then, with speech fully purified, one burns up worldly meditative absorption.

The sequence of the instruction that clarifies and explains is this:
A body three and a half cubits in height
is held to be the house of bliss.
Enjoyments that are impure and stained
should be begged for.
Attachment, aversion and delusion,
all of these should be cleared away.
By knowing in this way,
one goes to the abode of liberation.

Through the illusion of pairs embracing,
one should truly eat the taste.
Of the liquor endowed with compassion
one should drink the taste of emptiness.
The taste of the coemergent:
through that taste one is truly liberated.
By knowing in this way,

one comes to supreme joy.

Form of manifold aspects:
to slay that mind,
one should attend the lotus feet
of the supreme gurus.
All the kinds of sentient beings
should be regarded as equal.
For the one who knows in this way,
he fully engages the dharmas.
The worldly mind
and the mind of the Victor should be made equal.
Until the sixteenth year
one should not speak of faults.
Through one's own great Dharma
one should keep great protection.
With wisdom such as this
one should act in everything.

Body, speech and mind
are of a single nature.
The many powers of faults
should be made clear and stable.
With many offerings of liquor
one should make a net of the supreme wheel.
By knowing in this way,
one is liberated from saṃsāra.

Just as the moon in water
is seen to be unstable,
it is like the beings in a dream
who do not exist.
It is held to be like
beings conjured by illusion.
By knowing in this way,
one retains what one has heard.
Just like a wish-fulfilling jewel:
knowing thus, one should do recitation.
Just like a wish-granting tree:

such is their nature.
Just as the dust
of Ḍombipa's feet,
so should it be made equal to space.

The Commentary on Begging by Ḍombipa is complete.

In the city of Yambu in Nepal, the great and highly praised site of the upacchandoha, it was translated by the great grammarian Jitakarṇa and the translator, the Śākya monk Nyima Gyaltsen Palzangpo. May it be like the sun and moon upon the earth!

Translator's Notes

• The Tibetan reads "i li" for the vowel series; it is taken here as āli, the vowel series named later in the passage. In the line on the tangible, the written "deg bya" makes no sense and is read as "reg bya," the tangible, which completes the list of sense objects. In the four-syllable analysis, the third syllable is spelled "de" in the Tibetan though it evidently stands for the "te" of bhikṣante; it is given as spelled. "Bosmo," the fourth woman in the list of yoginīs, could not be identified with confidence and is left in phonetic form. The "eight word-stations" (tshig sa brgyad) is a literal rendering of an unclear term.
• In the line on attending the lotus feet, the Tibetan has an instrumental ("by the gurus of gurus") where the sense calls for a genitive; it is read as "the lotus feet of the supreme gurus." The "upacchandoha" renders the Tibetan term for one of the classes of sacred tantric sites; the passage applies it to the Kathmandu valley. "Great grammarian" is a literal rendering of the title given to Jitakarṇa.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.